dependence on the Soviet Union. They believed that some of the draft provisions curtailed India's freedom of action. Thus, in early 1970, the government would shelve even a subsequent draft that left "the commitment relatively vague."[61]

Some of these considerations also lay behind India's demurrals from joining or supporting Brezhnev's June 1969 proposal for an Asian collective security system. Some Indian opinion makers argued that the China threat meant that the government should take special note of the proposals and debate the continuing viability of nonalignment.[62] But Gandhi neither wanted to foreclose her options by leaning heavily to one side nor to provoke China by joining what was seen as an anti-China grouping. Thus Dinesh Singh publicly refused to endorse the Brezhnev idea and privately told Nixon that India would not join a military pact.[63] And on a trip to Japan, Gandhi reiterated that India did not support "collective security arrangements in Asia."[64]

Doubts about Soviet reliability and the desire to maintain flexibility through diversification meant that India continued to see the US as essential to its China containment strategy. As Kissinger put it to Nixon, "India sees Communist China as the main threat, and the US and USSR as major counters."[65] In Delhi, there were continued uncertainty about Chinese intentions and questions about the US stance. Haksar highlighted for Gandhi the critical issue to probe in talks scheduled with Rogers in May 1969: "Sino-American relations and the American view of Chinese aims, aspirations and postures."[66] And when Nixon visited India in July-August 1969, Indian foreign secretary Triloki Nath (T. N.) Kaul sought Kissinger's assessment of the threat from China, as well as the potential American approach to it.[67]

The Indian government was not just concerned about US policy vis-à-vis China but also the whole of Asia. Delhi remained torn about the US role in Southeast Asia. On the one hand, India wanted an end to the Vietnam War, which it thought American involvement perpetuated. Gandhi had publicly disagreed with Walt Rostow's contention that the American intervention in Vietnam had strengthened India's security versus China.[68] India wanted peace and stability in South and Southeast Asia, which could serve to limit Chinese influence and intervention.[69] On the other hand, as Kissinger outlined for Nixon, Indian officials worried that "a precipitate [US] pull-out